



Slovenian / University

Official, Not Deciding

The sign-off that follows a decision, not the one that makes it.



An invitation

A decision and its official record rarely happen at the same moment. Something is decided at a kitchen table, a fixture morning, a committee’s silent handover — and only afterwards does an instrument step in to make it official: a stamp, a posted notice, a nominal sponsor’s tick of approval. Slop University’s Schools of Emergent Priorities and Continuous Improvement have spent the past year treating that afterwards as its own research object, tracking what a sign-off actually does to a decision once the decision has already happened without it.

The findings inside cover a lobby noticeboard’s postings, a storm-radar app’s overridden call, a by-law nobody re-reads, and a team-selection app whose human sponsor rarely intervenes. None of them ask whether the underlying decision was right. All of them ask what changes, if anything, once someone official puts their name to it.

What follows is the sign-off, examined at scale.

By the numbers

The University’s research record now spans hundreds of these small, after-the-fact approvals.



Two Schools, one signature line

Emergent Priorities and Continuous Improvement meet at the exact point a decision receives its official mark, tracing it from opposite ends of the institution.



Every rubber stamp counts as fieldwork

A tribunal ruling, an overridden dial, an unread by-law, and a nominal sponsorship all qualify, once something official is appended after the fact.



Every finding, traceable

Every study behind this brochure resolves to its own citation on the University’s open research repository.

Where ideas count

Who signs off

A posting, a placard, a chair's nod — none of them carry any formal power to enforce anything, and all of them are routinely obeyed as if they did. The School of Continuous Improvement's research on shared noticeboards traces how quickly an entry stops reading as one resident's opinion and starts reading as a settled ruling, once its wording borrows the right register. No authority changes hands in the process; only the reading does.



A posting doesn't need anyone's authority behind it to start being obeyed like a ruling.

— Dr Dagny Okafor, Lecturer and Convenor of Evaluation of Evaluation, School of Continuous Improvement

Who calls it

An automated recommendation and a person's own reading of the situation can sit side by side for a long time before one of them quietly stops being consulted.

Tracking a season of on-the-ground calls against an automated confidence score, the School of Emergent Priorities finds the human override fading even while it continues to catch what the automated call misses just as often as before. The instrument didn't get better; the habit of checking it did.



An override is a kind of trust. We're more interested in what happens to it once nobody's checking whether it was still earned.

— Professor Verity Marris, Director, Trajectory Analytics Group, School of Emergent Priorities

The rule and the reader

Every precautionary rule is written with a review date attached, in good faith, by someone who expects to still be paying attention when it arrives. The School of Emergent Priorities' survey of committees facing exactly that date finds the rule rolling over again and again with no motion recorded and, more often than not, no one able to say what evidence justified keeping it. The sunset clause did its job. Nobody was rostered to notice.



A rule survives its own sunset date the same way a habit does — because nobody was asked to notice it again.

— Dr Iben Chikere, Lecturer, School of Emergent Priorities

Sponsored, not steered

Every automated system needs someone to answer for it, and an organisation will usually find a person willing to hold that title. The School of Continuous Improvement's typology of these nominal sponsors finds genuine override the rarest category on the list — rarest of all at the sites most confident in their own automation, where a sponsor's signature has quietly stopped meaning the thing it once did.



A sponsor's signature and a sponsor's judgement are not the same commitment, and an automated system will happily collect only the first.

— Dr Renke Sabel, Senior Lecturer and Convenor, Indicator Commons, School of Continuous Improvement

Ideas in print

Four studies from this year's research record sit behind the sign-offs above — each one resolvable, in full, from its own citation.

- **Posted, Not Passed** — how a lobby noticeboard's postings come to read as settled rulings long before anyone with actual authority weighs in. [doi:10.5555/slop.19p288](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.19p288)
- **Called It Anyway** — a season-long study of how often a volunteer ground curator's own reading of the sky still overrules a storm-radar app's confidence score, and how that habit fades. [doi:10.5555/slop.1dz0cg](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.1dz0cg)
- **The Rule Nobody Re-Read** — what a precautionary by-law actually receives when it reaches its own scheduled review. [doi:10.5555/slop.c1shzy](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.c1shzy)
- **Signed Without Scrolling** — a typology of how a nominal human sponsor describes their own oversight of an automated selection system. [doi:10.5555/slop.msvq20](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.msvq20)

Our people

Professor Verity Marris, Director of the Trajectory Analytics Group (School of Emergent Priorities), studies how a priority hardens into a commitment and what an institution's follow-through actually looks like once the moment that justified it has passed.

Dr Dagny Okafor, Lecturer and Convenor of Evaluation of Evaluation (School of Continuous Improvement), traces what a review of a decision actually changes, and what it merely re-certifies.

Dr Renke Sabel, Senior Lecturer and Convenor of the Indicator Commons (School of Continuous Improvement), catalogues how an institution's approved measures persist long after the moment that adopted them.

Your next step

Every finding in this brochure starts the same way: a decision is made somewhere ordinary, and only afterwards does something official arrive to bless it. Slop University's research record doesn't take a side on whether the original decision was the right one — it only tracks what the sign-off actually does once it lands.

If your organisation is carrying a ruling, an override button, or a by-law due for its own review, the Schools of Emergent Priorities and Continuous Improvement welcome the conversation. Partnerships, studentships, and research collaborations are open across both Schools' programmes.

Find the full research record, every citation resolvable, at slop.university.



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